

Arab Bank

One corporate spine, six countries — four programmes on a single relationship model

Corporate and commercial banking across six countries at \$64 billion in assets, delivered as four connected programmes rather than four country rollouts. What varies by market is far less than it first appears.

\$64B+

asset size

6

countries

600+

branches

4

programmes
delivered

50+

product
categories

90+

ready
connectors

DEPLOYMENT CONTEXT · PUBLICLY REPORTED

Corporate, commercial, SME and government segments · group hierarchy and related parties · multi-currency · 100+ reports and 22+ executive dashboards

Aditya Singh · Senior Manager — corporate banking programme delivery · 2023

Four programmes on one relationship model — because the corporate entity, not the country, is the thing the platform is actually organised around

Situation

A regional corporate bank operating across six countries, serving corporate, commercial, SME and government segments, with more than fifty product categories and a substantial branch network.

Relationships routinely span borders: a group headquartered in one market with subsidiaries, exposures and relationship managers in several others.

Complication

The obvious structure is a country rollout — deploy market by market, each with local requirements. That produces six configurations, six release trains and, critically, six versions of the same corporate group.

A group whose parent sits in one market and whose subsidiaries sit in three more cannot be represented correctly by any one of those six.

What was built instead

One corporate entity and hierarchy model, shared across all markets, with country expressed as an attribute of an entity rather than as a boundary between systems.

Four programmes then built on it: the relationship view, the sales lifecycle across four segments, account planning against targets, and the profitability and portfolio analytics layer.

THE NUMBERS THAT MATTER

1

entity model, six markets

4

programmes on one spine

4

segments, one lifecycle

50+

product categories

6

countries, one hierarchy

600+

users on the platform

The organising insight: in retail banking the country is a reasonable primary boundary, because customers rarely span markets. In corporate banking it is the wrong boundary — the group spans markets by definition, and any architecture that fragments on country fragments the very thing the bank is trying to see.

Deployment scale is publicly reported; the four programmes and the design position are from the delivery record

PUBLICLY REPORTED

Deployment context

Bank and deployment scale as publicly reported. Retained with attribution and not independently audited.

- \$64B+ asset size
- 600+ branches across 6 countries
- 600+ platform users
- 50+ product categories
- 90+ ready connectors
- 100+ reports, 22+ dashboards

DELIVERY RECORD

My ownership

Four corporate banking programmes delivered during the 2023 engagement.

- Corporate Client 360 and RM transformation
- Multi-country corporate sales lifecycle
- Target, achievement and account planning
- Profitability and portfolio dashboards
- Group and related-party model design
- Requirement through production

ILLUSTRATIVE

Modelled

The variance analysis and adoption figures illustrate the argument. Directional, not measured.

- Country variance decomposition
- Adoption curve by segment
- Configuration versus code split
- Replace with programme actuals
- Shape is the argument
- Method transfers unchanged

OUT OF SCOPE

Not claimed

Explicitly outside this case, so the boundary is unambiguous.

- Bank commercial or financial outcomes
- Any client or exposure data
- Any confidential design artefact
- Independently audited results
- Programmes outside the four listed
- Commercial terms of engagement

SCOPE

Four programmes, sequenced so each one made the next cheaper — the relationship model first, then everything that needs to see a relationship

\$64B+ asset size	600+ branches	6 countries	50+ product categories	90+ ready connectors	100+ reports delivered	22+ executive dashboards	600+ platform users
Corporate Client 360 and RM transformation - Group hierarchy and related parties - Single view of holdings and finances - RM ownership and coverage model - Onboarding with tax and identity checks	Multi-country corporate sales lifecycle - Corporate, commercial, SME, government - Origination to execution, one lifecycle - Scoring and rule-based escalation - Predictive opportunity health scoring			Target, achievement and account planning - Planned against actual, RM and portfolio - Wallet and share-of-relationship measures - Seasonality and period handling - Record freezing at period close		Profitability and portfolio dashboards - Client and portfolio profitability views - Transaction banking contribution - Global group consolidated position - Risk-weighted return on assets	

Why this order

- The sales lifecycle needs a corporate entity and a group hierarchy to attach a deal to.
- Account planning needs both the entity and the pipeline to plan against.
- Profitability needs all three plus one definition of a client.

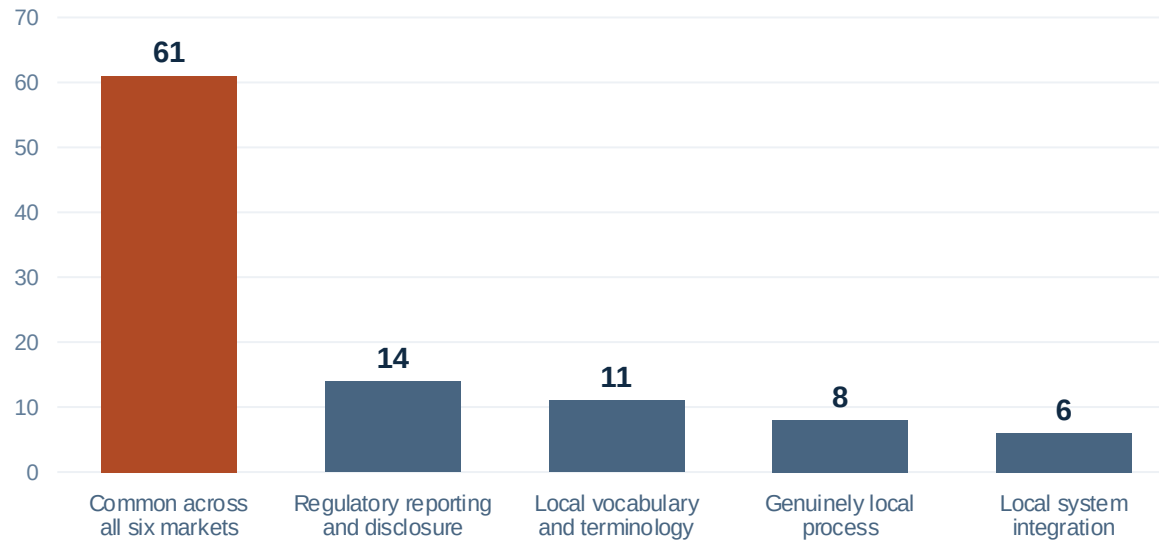
What each contributed to the spine

- Programme one built the entity, hierarchy and coverage model — the largest single investment.
- Programme two added the deal object and the segment-aware lifecycle.
- Programmes three and four added almost nothing structural — as intended.

The dependency worth noticing

- Profitability is where inconsistent definitions surface. If two programmes disagree about what a client is, the dashboard is where the bank finds out.
- Sequencing it last is not a deprioritisation — it is a deliberate reconciliation checkpoint.
- Built early it would have measured a model still moving.

Country variance turned out to be far smaller than expected — most of what looked local was either regulatory reporting or vocabulary



Illustrative decomposition of corporate banking requirements by variance type

How each category is handled

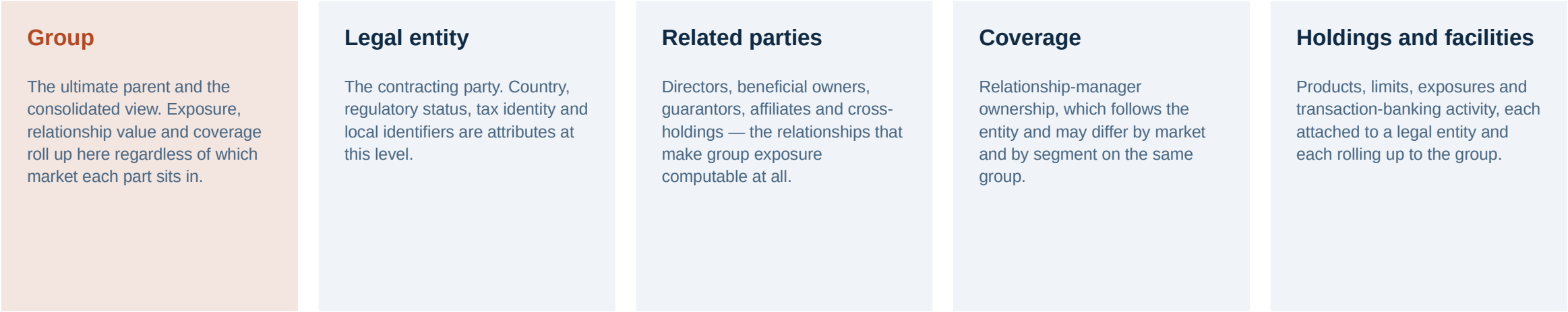
- Common — built once, deployed everywhere. This is the majority and it is the reason a single spine works at all.
- Regulatory reporting — a reporting-layer variation, not a data-model one. The underlying records are identical.
- Vocabulary — configuration. Different names for the same object, which is a labelling problem people routinely mistake for a structural one.
- Genuinely local process — the real variance, and it is small. Handled as configured process variants on the shared lifecycle.
- Local integration — country-specific connectors at the interface layer, with the internal model untouched.

Why the variance is systematically overestimated at the start

Each country team is asked what is different about their market, and each answers honestly and at length. Nobody is asked what is the same, so the common majority is never counted — and the requirement set that emerges reads as though every market is unique.

The correction is a specific one and it is worth doing early: run the requirement workshop against a shared baseline rather than a blank page. Ask each market what it needs to change about a common design, not what it needs. The same people produce a dramatically shorter list, and the list they produce is the real variance.

The corporate entity model carries everything — and country is an attribute of an entity, never a boundary between systems



What this makes possible

- A group view that is correct even when the parent, the subsidiaries and the coverage sit in different markets.
- Consistent exposure and relationship-value roll-up without reconstructing it from country extracts.
- One definition of a client, which is what makes cross-programme reporting agree.

What a country-boundary model loses

- The group view has to be assembled from six sources, each with its own version of the hierarchy.
- Related-party relationships that cross borders have no home — they belong to neither country's instance.
- Every consolidated number becomes a reconciliation exercise rather than a query.

The cost of doing it this way

- The entity model has to be agreed across six markets before the first one goes live, which is slower to start.
- It requires a decision authority above any single country, which is a governance change, not a technical one.
- Those are real costs and they are paid once, at the beginning.

Corporate, commercial, SME and government differ in threshold and evidence, not in shape — which is why one configured lifecycle serves all four

Segment	What differs	What is identical	Handled as
Corporate	Approval thresholds, committee level, financial-statement depth	Deal object, stages, ownership, disposition set	Configured variant
Commercial	Delegated authority limits, documentation requirements	Deal object, stages, ownership, disposition set	Configured variant
SME	Scorecard-led assessment, lighter evidence, faster path	Deal object, stages, ownership, disposition set	Configured variant
Government	Procurement conformity, additional approvals, tender linkage	Deal object, stages, ownership, disposition set	Configured variant

The test that settled it	Why this is worth insisting on	Where the pressure comes from
- Ask whether the deal moves through different states, or the same states under different rules. - Across all four segments the states were identical — originate, qualify, structure, approve, execute, book. - Different states would have meant four lifecycles. Different rules means one lifecycle and four rule sets.	- One lifecycle means one pipeline report, one set of conversion metrics and one definition of stage. - A bank with four lifecycles cannot compare segment performance without a translation layer that nobody maintains. - Adding a fifth segment becomes configuration rather than a project.	- Each segment team experiences its own rules as fundamental differences, and argues for its own process. - They are describing real differences — but in thresholds and evidence, not in shape. - Separating those two things in the requirement workshop is most of the work.

What held, what did not, and what I would do differently on the next multi-country corporate programme

What held

- Treating the corporate group, not the country, as the primary organising object.
- Running requirement workshops against a shared baseline rather than a blank page — it produced a far shorter and far truer variance list.
- Sequencing profitability last, so that it acted as a reconciliation checkpoint on definitions rather than measuring a moving model.
- One lifecycle across four segments, with difference expressed as rules rather than as shape.

What did not

- Related-party data quality was underestimated. The model was right; the source data on cross-holdings and beneficial ownership was materially incomplete in several markets.
- That is not a platform problem, but it is the platform's problem the moment a group view is presented as authoritative.
- Reporting definitions were agreed programme by programme, so the fourth programme spent real effort reconciling three earlier interpretations of the same measure.

What I would change

- Run a related-party data assessment before the entity model is signed off, not after — the model's value is bounded by that data.
- Agree the reporting definition set once, in programme one, even though nothing reports yet.
- Name a group-level data authority early. Six markets cannot converge on a hierarchy without someone empowered to decide.
- Publish the variance decomposition to country teams. Seeing that most requirements are common changes the conversation.

The pattern behind all three columns

Everything that held was a decision about what the shared object is — the group, the lifecycle, the baseline. Everything that did not was a shared thing left unowned: related-party data quality and reporting definitions both belonged to the portfolio and were treated as belonging to whichever programme happened to need them first.

Four judgements for multi-country corporate banking

- | | | |
|----|--|---|
| 01 | Organise on the group, not the country | Country is a defensible primary boundary in retail because customers rarely span markets. In corporate banking the group spans markets by definition, so a country-boundary architecture fragments exactly the thing the bank is trying to see. |
| 02 | Workshop against a baseline, never a blank page | Asking a market what it needs produces a long list of differences. Asking what it needs to change about a shared design produces a short one — and the short list is the real variance. |
| 03 | Separate different shape from different rules | Segments almost always differ in thresholds and evidence rather than in states. Different rules means one lifecycle configured four ways; only different states justify four lifecycles. |
| 04 | Assess the data before trusting the model | A group hierarchy is only as good as the related-party data feeding it. That assessment belongs before the entity model is signed off, because the model's value is bounded by data nobody has checked. |

Six countries did not need six deployments. They needed one entity model agreed before the first go-live — which is slower to start, requires authority above any single market, and is paid for exactly once.